

as old as the first humans to perceive those differences.

Superheroes are the feel-good, daydreams of someone who was oppressed and wronged, fantasising about being given enough power to right the world by getting rid of the things they perceive to be evil. The problem is, absolute power usually corrupts absolutely, which is a very real facet of humanity that superheroes ignore.

More and more people are starting to speak out against the whole superhero trend, including notable filmmakers and actors. Jodie Foster said that studios were transforming movies into theme parks and making bad content for the masses in order to make a quick buck. Simon Pegg, the British comedian, borders on a conspiracy theory by paraphrasing French philosopher Jean Baudrillard, and suggesting that the powers that be keep people occupied with the same things that occupied them as children, so as to distract them from the real problems of society. He calls it the infantilization of society. Many more people have spoken up against the blockbuster superhero action flicks that spend a hundred million on special effects and have characters that have the depth of an evaporating shallow puddle.

MUSIC

For years, the music industry has felt threatened by technology, or at least new developments in formats. Those of us old enough to remember the humble cassette tape will remember how much of a big deal the music industry made about the piracy that all of us were indulging in when we made mix tapes, or recorded songs from the radio on to our cassettes and shared them around with friends. Of course the same logic applies to the music industry as it does to software and movies – cassettes helped transport music to places it wouldn't have got on its own before, and it helped out a huge amount of musicians that would have stayed underground and unknown had they not been able to spread their music easily, which cassettes allowed.

Then of course we all know what happened with MP3s and Napster and all the other piracy gateways that cropped up. The same fears were repeated and of course the Music industry just moved on to video content which meant that our low-bandwidth connections of the time were again useless if we wanted to enjoy music in video format. Of course purists that were not affected by this shift towards music videos would have still got to enjoy their music with their eyes closed, as they were lost in bliss, serenaded by every pristine note... or whatever it is that pretentious audiophiles do with their overpriced gear...

The point we're making is that the music industry had to adapt to every technological advancement, and evolution of this sort ends up killing off a few genres or styles. What technology did for music was to make it readily available to everyone across the world, which should be a good thing, and for the most part it was. However, what this did was to take rock music, or grunge, metal, rap, etc., all of which were rebellions against the music establishment, and made them so popular that they became the establishment themselves!

Of course, technology did more than just that, it also meant that computers got involved in music production in more and more ways.

Purists will point to guitar effects and synthesizers as the beginning of the destruction of pure music and the natural sound of instruments, and they're probably right.

However, modern computers can modulate all signals so well that we end up with autotune, for example, which changes the pitch of a human voice, in real time, so that you can literally sing out of tune, and the computer will make sure you stay in tune. In essence, it's not the voice of a singer, or even the skill of an instrument player that matters anymore in music, but showmanship and the ability to entertain large crowds. The "show" part of show business.

For the "business" part of show business, we can thank technology for helping the music industry force stuff down our collective throats using technology. Not only is music now scientifically designed to be attractive to as many ears as possible, thanks to algorithms we're forced to encounter that kind of music all the time as well. The cover of this issue is inspired by an earworm of a song called Everything is Awesome from the Lego Movie – it's just one of those songs that everyone we know seems to like.

VIDEO GAMES AND SPORTS

This is a strange one, because video games themselves are a product of



Credit: MTV.com

What is it exactly that the yearly MTV Video Music Awards celebrate?